

Christ Now Liveth in Me

Paul is writing to the Roman community, including the Jewish community in Rome. They were struggling with the promise God made to Abraham including Gentiles who had never kept the law.

That is why Romans 3 begins with:

"What advantage then hath the Jew?
or what profit is there of circumcision?"

Paul answers, "Much every way," because to them were committed the oracles of God.

By Romans 5, Paul reveals the two Adams: the fall of the world through Adam, the inheritance of spiritual death, and how far spiritual death could take the human race. Then he turns the other side of the coin: through the abundance of grace and the gift of righteousness, the born-again man can reign in life all the way to eternal life.

That is exciting.

Romans 6 shows the redemption of both Jew and Gentile. We were baptized into Jesus' death. Our old man was crucified with Him, and the body of sin was destroyed.

The body of sin is not primarily the physical body. The old man that was crucified was the old nature, and the body of sin was the inner housing of that nature in the spirit. That is the part that was destroyed.

Jesus came into a world already condemned by spiritual death. He said:

"I came not to condemn the world...
but that the world through him might be saved."

Every Old Testament saint who heeded God's promise was waiting for the Firstborn from the dead, Jesus, so they would have the image to conform to. The world was spiritually dead, and then one Man came with life in Him.

John says:

"In him was life;
and the life was the light of men."

His human spirit was fathered by God through the Holy Spirit, so He was born spiritually alive. One candle stood in four thousand years of darkness.

Jesus died spiritually so that, when we accepted Him as Savior, we could be baptized into His death as our Substitute. In God's eyes, when you accepted Him, He died in your place, so you died with Him.

Then you could be resurrected with Him into His life.

Romans 6:5 says:

"For if we have been planted together in the likeness of his death,
we shall be also in the likeness of his resurrection."

We often push that only to the future resurrection of the body. That future resurrection is included, but Paul is first talking about the resurrection of the human spirit in the new birth.

Romans 8:23 says that those who have the firstfruits of the spirit groan, waiting for the adoption process to be completed in the redemption of the body. We groan because we have a new nature that freed us from sin, while still living in a body capable of sin.

Meanwhile, learn to reign from the new nature.

If we remove the italicized helper words in Romans 6:5, the thought stays tighter:

If we have been planted together in the likeness of His death, we shall be of resurrection.

My spirit has already been resurrected, even while I live on this outpost called earth.

Romans 6:6-7 says:

"Knowing this, that our old man is crucified with him,
that the body of sin might be destroyed,
that henceforth we should not serve sin.
For he that is dead is freed from sin."

The old man died, had a funeral, and was destroyed. That is why he is free.

Romans 2:1 says:

"Therefore thou art inexcusable, O man,
whosoever thou art that judgest:
for wherein thou judgest another,
thou condemnest thyself;
for thou that judgest doest the same things."

Paul is addressing the Jew who judged the Gentile sins listed in Romans 1. Those sins were horrible, but Paul says, "You judge them, yet do the same things."

Romans 2:17-24 says the Jew rests in the law, boasts in God, knows His will, approves excellent things, and teaches others. Then Paul asks:

"Thou therefore which teachest another,
teachest thou not thyself?
thou that preachest a man should not steal,
dost thou steal?"

They believed the law saved them, but their own transgression showed otherwise.

Romans 2:25-29 says circumcision profits if you keep the law. But if you break the law, your circumcision becomes uncircumcision.

If the uncircumcised Gentile keeps the righteousness of the law through the new birth, does that not judge the circumcised Jew who has the letter and still transgresses?

Paul says:

"He is not a Jew, which is one outwardly...
But he is a Jew, which is one inwardly;
and circumcision is that of the heart,
in the spirit, and not in the letter."

The promise to Abraham is fulfilled in the inward man, where the old man is cut away and replaced with the new man. Through Christ, all nations are blessed. I have inherited the promise of Abraham because I have been born again.

Romans 3:19-20 says:

"Now we know that what things soever the law saith,
it saith to them who are under the law:
that every mouth may be stopped,
and all the world may become guilty before God.
Therefore by the deeds of the law
there shall no flesh be justified in his sight:
for by the law is the knowledge of sin."

The law spoke to Israel, but its standard stopped every mouth and declared the whole world guilty. Not one man could keep the righteousness of the law because no one had the nature to do it.

The law was added because of transgressions. It was the schoolmaster that revealed spiritual death and declared both Jew and Gentile under sin.

Then the sacrificial system was added so Israel could continue to serve God's altars until the true sacrifice came.

Animals could not cleanse the conscience from sin. At Solomon's temple dedication, thousands of animals were sacrificed, and it still could not change the nature.

The priesthood, the sacrifices, the outer court, the holy place, and the holiest of holies were shadows. The scapegoat carried the sins of the people into the wilderness to be destroyed.

Jesus fulfilled that type. Your sins were laid on Him. He cried:

"My God, my God, why hast thou forsaken me?"

He died spiritually and descended into the lower parts. Like the scapegoat, He was sent into the place of darkness, but in your place.

He never sinned. He was made sin. He took your nature of sin, and the claims of justice were settled in Him.

Romans 7 returns to the Jewish community and explains what happened under the law.

The spiritually dead Jew was married to God through the law, but the motions of sin which were by the law worked in his members to bring forth fruit unto death.

That did not mean the law killed a living spirit. The Jew was already spiritually dead. The commandment set sin into motion against his will and exposed the nature that was already there.

Where there is no law, sin is not imputed. That does not mean men were free from spiritual death. It means there was no commandment setting sin into motion against their will and proving their guilt.

Scripture says:

"What man knoweth the things of a man,
save the spirit of man which is in him?"

A spiritually dead spirit can only search the things of spiritually dead man. But now the born-again spirit searches the deep things of God.

Why would the Holy Spirit need to search God as though God did not know Himself? The point is that, through the new nature, I now have access into God. My spirit is hungry and searches God continually, and the Holy Spirit accommodates that searching.

The life that was in Jesus has become my life. Now I can know the things freely given to me by God.

Romans 7:1-4 says the law has dominion over a man as long as he lives. A woman is bound to her husband while he lives, but if he dies, she is free to marry another.

Paul concludes:

"Wherefore, my brethren,
ye also are become dead to the law by the body of Christ;
that ye should be married to another,
even to him who is raised from the dead."

The old man who was married to God through the law was crucified with Christ. The body of sin was destroyed. That old man no longer exists, so Israel was freed from the law to be married to the risen Christ.

Now we serve in newness of spirit, not oldness of letter.

Galatians 2:20 says:

"I am crucified with Christ:
nevertheless I live;
yet not I,
but Christ liveth in me."

The old man has been destroyed. Yet I live, but not the old man. Christ lives in me.

What is the Spirit of Christ? It is not the Holy Spirit being renamed. The Holy Spirit is the third Person of the Godhead.

As the Father has life in Himself, He gave to the Son to have life in Himself. That was not eternal deity being created; Jesus had glory with the Father before the world was. The life spoken of there is the life in His human spirit. In Him was life, and that life was the light of men.

I do not have Jesus' personal human spirit. I have my own. But the same life that was in His human spirit is now in mine because I was quickened together with Him.

I no longer have the spirit of Adam, the spiritual death I inherited from him. I have the Spirit of Christ, the life of the last Adam in my own born-again human spirit.

Jesus told the disciples to rejoice not merely that devils were subject to them, but that their names were written in heaven.

You can be a distant relative and still have relationship. But fellowship is two fellows in the same ship because they want to be there. God wants more than distant relationship. He wants fellowship with you as His son.

He does not want to wait until heaven before dealing with you as a son. Worship Him now. Get to know Him now.

No problem in this world is bigger than who He made you.

Sometimes trouble starts the journey. Lester Sumrall, as a young man, saw people falling into hell and answered his call. God healed him, and later he learned faith under hard conditions.

What starts you is not the issue. Once you get far enough into God, the original pressure is swallowed up in who He is and who you are in Him.

The tragedy is being stirred by trouble, getting close enough to be rescued, and then going right back to serving the flesh.

Once you get in, stay there.